SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #39 · CHURCH CULTURE AND EXPECTATIONS

“My church's rules are the same as God's love.”

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Where it often comes from

Where rules about dress, music, entertainment, or conduct are taught as the heart of faith, breaking one can feel like losing God’s favor. We confuse a community’s customs with God’s character and cannot tell where the church ends and God begins.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said, “You have disregarded the commandment of God to keep the tradition of men.” Paul writes, “It is for freedom that Christ has set us free. Stand firm, then, and do not be encumbered once more by a yoke of slavery.” He also warns against human rules, “Do not handle, do not taste, do not touch!” which “are of no value against the indulgence of the flesh.” And “neither death nor life… nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord.” God’s love is not earned by keeping a church’s rules. Real obedience flows from that love.

> *“It is for freedom that Christ has set us free. Stand firm, then, and do not be encumbered once more by a yoke of slavery”* (Galatians 5:1).

Also see

> “You have disregarded the commandment of God to keep the tradition of men” (Mark 7:8).

> “If you have died with Christ to the spiritual forces of the world, why, as though you still belonged to the world, do you submit to its regulations: ‘Do not handle, do not taste, do not touch!’? These will all perish with use, because they are based on human commands and teachings. Such restrictions indeed have an appearance of wisdom, with their self-prescribed worship, their false humility, and their harsh treatment of the body; but they are of no value against the indulgence of the flesh” (Colossians 2:20–23).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

> “Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me; for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For My yoke is easy and My burden is light” (Matthew 11:28–30).

Common self-statements

- If I break a rule, God is angry.
- The rules are what God wants.
- I am only loved if I conform.
- If they disapprove, God does too.
- I am safe when I follow every rule.
- I cannot question.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either obedient to all rules or rejected.
- Mind reading: Assuming the church speaks for God in everything.

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that God is displeased.
- Fortune telling: Predicting punishment for any deviation.

Challenging questions

- Which rules are in Scripture, and which are customs?
- What does Scripture say is the heart of God's will?
- How do I feel when I break a church rule?
- Does God's love depend on my keeping those rules?
- Who in my church lives in freedom and love?
- What would help me sort out the difference?

Truth summary

> God's love is not the same as my church's rules. I can honor godly leaders and clear Scripture while recognizing human customs. Nothing can separate me from the love of God in Christ.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grace
- Church
- Obedience
- God, All Loving
- Guilt/Shame

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Love
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My church's rules are the same as God's love"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My church's rules are the same as God's love." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Which rules are Scripture?
- ☐ What is the heart of God's will?
- ☐ How do I feel when I break a rule?
- ☐ Does God's love depend on them?
- ☐ Who lives in freedom?
- ☐ What helps me sort it out?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Christ has set me free.
- ☐ Human traditions are not God's commands.
- ☐ Nothing can separate me from God's love.
- ☐ Christ's yoke is easy.
- ☐ I can honor leaders and test teaching.
- ☐ I obey out of love, not fear.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 5:1**
  "It is for freedom that Christ has set us free. Stand firm, then, and do not be encumbered once more by a yoke of slavery."
- ☐ **Romans 8:38–39**
  "For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord."
- ☐ **Matthew 11:28–30**
  "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me; for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For My yoke is easy and My burden is light."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Love, not fear: Each week, note one act of obedience out of love, not fear.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Galatians 5:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Christ has set me free, and nothing can separate me from His love.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Sort the rules. Write which are Scripture and which are custom.
- [ ] Study Galatians 5. Read and underline freedom.
- [ ] Talk with a mature believer. Ask for help sorting.
- [ ] Pray Romans 8:38–39. Thank God His love holds.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My church's rules are the same as God's love": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Love, not fear
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My church's rules are the same as God's love.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You love me apart from rules. Help me tell Your commands from human customs, obey out of love, and rest in Your grace. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.